The Mirror

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Chapter 1

Mirror

You know something is wrong when you wake up and you don't see your own image in the mirror. Could it be that something happened to your reflection? Like maybe, it got captured... or worse? And what if you could go and save your reflection? Or *maybe* your *reflection* could save *you*...

Jack woke up extremely tired. He broke his alarm clock for the fiftieth time, and then rolled off his bed. He pulled on his school clothes and went to the bathroom. Without looking at the mirror, Jack brushed his hair and threw some water at his teeth. He was about to leave when he looked up at himself. He was gone.

Wait, that didn't make any sense. Jack started to wake up. What was going on? Why was he invisible? He looked down at himself. He was still there. Not invisible. Maybe it was a problem with the mirror. No, that didn't make any sense either. He picked up the comb. The comb didn't float in mid air. But the mirror was definitely not just a picture either, because when he turned his head the picture of the room stayed three-dimensional and moved.

"Umm… am I dreaming?" Jack thought. He pinched himself. *"Nope."*

Well, there was only one thing to do, and that was to *touch* the mirror. Jack reached out his hand…and tapped the mirror. Nothing happened. He tapped it again. Still, nothing happened. Then he tapped it once more. Figuring he had better get to school before he was late, Jack ran downstairs, grabbed a banana, and raced to the bus stop.

Chapter 2

Gone

Jack noticed something was wrong the minute he stepped onto the bus. His friend Chad didn't greet him as usual. Actually, he looked a little confused when Jack started to sit down.

“Uhh… who are you?” he asked.

“Come on, Chad. You’ve pulled that joke before and it’s not funny,” Jack said irritably.

“Umm… this is really awkward, but I don’t even know your name.”

“It’s Jack,” he said, knowing he would look dumb.

The bus started moving. Jack slung his backpack onto the floor of the bus and started eating his banana.

A change occurred in Chad’s face. He wasn’t just confused now, he felt insulted. “Okay, you’ve had your joke, random kid. Now go back to your *funny* friends and leave me alone. We’re not friends and you know it.”

Now it was Jack’s turn to feel insulted. Chad was not sounding like Chad. If he really *was* joking, he wouldn’t have gone *this* far.

“Hey, hey.” Jack said, “I don’t know what’s going on! I’m not joking. We’re friends, and *you* know it. Why the change?”

Chad stood up, his face red and steamy.

“You’re mean.” he said hurtfully, before walking away and finding a seat at the back of the bus.

Jack was completely confounded. What had happened to Chad? Or what happened to *him*? Wait a second. Now Jack was really awake. He connected the mirror and Chad. He had been invisible… wait, was Jack, *gone*?

Now things came to him. In the mirror, Jack had been invisible. When he tapped it, Jack disappeared from the world. Which probably meant that… Jack was in the mirror dimension! It had been a portal. Of course, everything was the same in the mirror dimension except that… *he wasn’t there*.

Jack started to *panic*. He had to get off the bus, back to the mirror, tap it, and go back home where he existed. The Chad in the real world was probably *super* confused that his friend was gone. Or maybe he just thought he was sick…and Jack’s parents would think he had gone to school. No one would even *notice* Jack was gone for a long time.

He raced up to the front of the bus. “Bus driver, stop! I need to go back home!!”

“Sorry, kid,” the female bus driver said, “I can’t help unless it’s *really* an emergency.”

“Oh it is,” Jack said, trying to think of a good lie that could get him back home. “Um…I forgot my math textbook! I know where it is, it’s on my—”

“ —Look,” the bus driver said, turning the steering wheel, “that’s no emergency. I have to drive.”

She refocused on the road and ignored Jack’s desperate pleas.

“*Great*,” Jack thought. Now he was lying to people on top of being stranded in the mirror dimension. He had better hurry up and get home soon. He hoped the portal wouldn’t turn off and leave him.

The bus turned into the driveway of the school.

Chapter 3

Math

Jack slung his backpack into the seat he normally sat in. His classmates filed into their respective desks. He wondered why the seats were the same even though he didn’t exist. He remembered requesting a seating chart revision for some chatterers in the class. But if he didn’t exist...

Mr. Freeman walked up to the front of the room. He began to take attendance and went through the whole list, without Jack’s name in it, before he realized there was a “new” student in the class.

“Um, excuse me, but I believe you’re in the wrong class, young man,” Mr. Freeman said sternly to Jack.

“Oh, uh, I’m a new transfer,” Jack said in reply.

“Oh,” the teacher said, unconvinced. “Are you sure? Principal Johnson usually notifies me when we get new students.”

“Don’t worry about it,” Jack assured Mr. Freeman, “she’ll tell you by tomorrow.”

“Okay then,” Mr. Freeman said, then he walked off and began class.

Chapter 4

The Aftermath

When Mr. Freeman had finished explaining scatter plots, outliers and clusters, and the students had begun to exit the room with a homework assignment, he walked over to Jack's seat and began to speak.

"New student, um… you haven't told me your name yet. What is it?"

"Jack," replied Jack honestly.

"Okay, *Jack*, I emailed the principal and she said that there were no new students coming to PS. 13, and that she had no idea someone else had been in our school. Please explain to me what you are doing, and where you came from."

Jack sagged. He didn't know what to tell Mr. Freeman. He had already lied and the math teacher was prone to think he was doing it again.

"I really—*really*—have to go to the restroom. Excuse me," Jack said quickly, starting to push toward the exit.

"You aren't going anywhere until I get some answers." Mr. Freeman said firmly. "We can't have hitchhikers coming to our school without having the paperwork done."

"Okay," Jack said, doing a fake potty dance. "Do you *really* want the truth, because it's *really* crazy."

"Yes. But no lies."

"*Uh-oh.*" Jack thought, "*He's going to think I'm lying. But I still have to tell the truth.*"

"I woke up this morning as a normal kid. But when I went into my bathroom, the mirror showed me as invisible. Obviously, when I looked at myself, I *wasn't* invisible. Then I tapped it. I think it transported me to the mirror dimension, which is where I'm at now, no offense to you or any other inhabitants of this weird world. Everything is the same, except that I previously didn't exist. In the real world—I mean my *old* world—I was one of your best students and we were on good terms"

Mr. Freeman stared at him blankly. Of course, he thought Jack was lying, and for good reason too.

“Fine. You may go. And I’ll tell the other teachers not to bug you with it.”

“Gee, thanks!” Jack exclaimed, happily starting to leave, “See you around! Or not.”

As Jack ran out of the room, he noticed a figure turn and walk in the opposite direction he was going in. It almost looked like he had been listening.

Chapter 5

Lunch

Jack finished three other subjects and stumbled into the cafeteria to eat his lunch. He grabbed a plate of spaghetti glop and handed the lunch lady a wad of one dollar bills. He found a seat that was empty—Jack didn’t want to upset Chad anymore—and silently ate his lunch. A group of girls gathered at the table next to him and started chatting away about shopping and salons and popular boys and a bunch of other stuff. Jack wasn’t really listening. But his ears perked up when he heard Chad’s name uttered.

“He always looks so lonely.”

“Yeah, I know what you mean. I wish he had a real friend.”

One girl’s face went red and she said, “Girls!” Some of them giggled.

Jack turned away and pulled his hood over his head.

A few minutes later, Jack spotted Chad. He was sitting alone with a guy in a hoodie. They were exchanging a few words. Hoodie Dude made a hand motion. They kept talking, and both seemed a little concerned about some problem.

The dude left after a minute. He started walking toward Jack. He kept going until he got to Jack’s table, and without asking, sat down.

“Well, now, Jack Daniel Charleson.”

“Uhh… how do you know my full name?” Jack asked. He was shocked. He had never told anyone in the mirror dimension his last name or his middle name.

“We have to speak in private.”

There was no arguing, so Jack followed the guy in the black hoodie until they were out of the cafeteria.

Chapter 6

Jack Two

Jack walked into the bathroom.

“How do I put this lightly so you don’t scream?” Hoodie Guy asked.

“Umm… just don’t tell me,” Jack suggested.

“You have to know. Your—our—lives are in jeopardy.”

“Okay,” Jack said, bracing himself, “Just *do* tell me.”

“I’m you.”

“What?”

“Take it literally. I. Am. You.” Hoodie dude pulled his tightly drawn hoodie down to reveal a face very similar in every way to Jack’s face except his eyes seemed older and wiser, and there was a scar under his eye.

“But… But…” Jack stuttered.

“It’s okay. You look at me all the time. In the mirror,” Jack Two said.

“Huh? I am *so* confused. This has to do with this morning, right?” Jack One asked.

“Yes. This morning and every other time you’ve looked into the mirror. I’m your mirror twin. Every time you look into the mirror, I’m there also looking at the mirror. We both have free will except that our wills are the same. In fact, everything in each other’s worlds is exactly the same. Think about that for a minute.”

Jack One stood in the restroom letting it sink in for five or so minutes.

“Soo… I get that. It’s hard, but I get it. But there’s still a problem. How did you get to my side of the mirror?” Jack One asked.

“Opposite way around,” Jack Two said, “You’re on *my* side of the mirror. Every mirror is a portal into the mirror dimension—except no one can

use them because their mirror twin blocks them. So when you tapped the mirror you instantly switched to my side of the mirror."

"That explains everything…and nothing." Jack One said. "Explain again—or for the first time, I mean—why you weren't at the mirror this morning? I thought our wills aligned."

"They did," Jack Two said, "until that one fateful day…"

Chapter 7

Mirror Tappers

"One year ago—well it was actually less than a day ago—it was midnight and I was up reading my favorite story. I finally shut the book and dropped off into sleep. I woke up suddenly and heard banging. Then my closet creaked open. Out stepped a skeleton. It was black and charred like it had been burned. It had purple eyes and held a sword.

"It was a Mirror Tapper Skeleton. One of three types of Mirror Tappers including Vampires, Skeletons, and Borgs. They are the only living things that operate only on one side of the mirror. They upset the 'equilibrium' of the two sides of the mirror.

"Anyways, the Skeleton eyed me and went to capture me. I screamed and ran, but the Skeleton was too fast and caught me. It took me into my closet that was somehow a portal and sent me to a tower. The tower was in the middle of the Mirror Tappers' base. There were more people in the tower than just me. Kids, adults, old people, and even babies. But we all had one thing in common: nobody cared about us. Meaning we were civilians. We weren't powerful or super rich. We didn't have a ton of connections to people and didn't go to a good college or, well, any college for me.

"I stayed there for a year. I was fed food and drink that was old and tasted bad. The only thing I could do was talk to the others that were captured. They told me all kinds of stories. It was actually really fun. But I missed my normal life and my family. However, I learned a lot from the

others. I learned everything I just told you about Mirror Tappers, and I learned, more importantly, how to escape.

"When someone new entered that tower, they came from a chute. It was lined with grease and had a door with a latch that only opened when someone was coming into the tower and never out of it. I waited for someone to come in. When they did, I sprung. I grabbed the door before it shut and crawled in. It was slippery inside. I tried for hours and hours to get out. I was hungry. But finally I did it. However, there was a latch to the door at the top of the chute. I waited desperately for someone to come in. I knew I could always go down and get food, but I would never have another chance. Already I knew that the Mirror Tappers would be ready to capture me the moment I came down. But that's not what they had in mind…

"Finally, when I was about to go down again, the door opened. I raced out into the blinding light, and…I was caught. A couple Skeleton Mirror Tappers had tricked me. I frantically tried to escape but they had a firm grip on my arms and legs. They carried me kicking and screaming down the hallway towards solitary confinement. Everything looked bleaker than before and I was about to be doomed to a miserable life, but then luck saved me.

"The tower was attacked. I don't know who it was, but there was a large physical force trying to siege the tower. The skeletons were called to battle, dropped me on the ground, and raced off to an armory. I was free!

"To make a long story short—I've gone on long enough—I managed to escape from the tower. I fell from the sky—their base was in the clouds—and I hit some magical barrier. It teleported me home, just after the bus had left. I checked the calendar, and discovered only a couple hours had passed in my year of living. I found the mirror empty, figured you had tapped the mirror while I was gone, and biked all the way to school. I talked to Chad about what had happened on the bus. He didn't know me. I think there was some magic in that tower that wiped my name from everybody's memories and all servers and papers.

“And that’s the story. I’ll leave you to think about it, and you can ask me questions later after school. By the way, just call me Daniel, because that’s our middle name.”

And with that, Daniel concluded his story about the Mirror Tappers, and he left Jack standing dumbfounded in the bathroom.

Chapter 8

After School

Jack’s other classes zoomed by. He couldn’t stop thinking of Daniel and Mirrors and Mirror Tappers. So he was on the wrong side of the mirror? He had so many questions.

Finally the end of school came. Jack found Daniel waiting in the lobby. They walked to the end of an empty hallway and started talking.

“So…do you have any questions?” Daniel asked.

“Yeah. I get what happened to you. You got abducted last night and the tower made it extend to a year. I didn’t get captured because I was on the opposite side of the mirror, and Mirror Tappers don’t have a reflection. But—excuse me if this question is dumb—but how come you aren’t backwards? I mean I see you flipped whenever I look into the mirror.”

Daniel laughed. “That’s pretty simple: It’s just an effect of the mirror.”

“Oh, I guess that makes sense,” Jack said, “But now to the important question. I still don’t understand why I’m in danger. I’ll go back home, tap the mirror, return, and live my life normally again. I mean, you probably won’t be at the mirror the same time I am all the time, and we can probably communicate through the mirror since we both know it’s a portal, but besides that we’ll be fine.”

“Why are you not getting this?” Daniel was getting annoyed. “The Mirror Tappers! They know I’ve escaped. It’s only been like, half of a day, since I got back. They’ll want to capture both of us. They can’t have two kids that are in different dimensions of the mirror roaming around! The Mirror Tappers will think we’re going to let the cat out of the bag. And

besides, since we both are creatures who are uneven to the balance of the mirror, we will destroy everything!"

"Oh," Jack said. He hadn't thought of it that way. This was worse than he thought. "If only I hadn't tapped the mirror this morning!"

"It wouldn't have helped. They want both of us now. Even if you only didn't see your reflection, people would get curious and things would get weird. The Mirror Tappers are after *us*," Daniel said, dead serious.

"Sooo…what do we do now?" Jack asked.

Chapter 9

The Battle

Jack and Daniel raced into their house. The bus was a little late in coming. They ran up into the backyard, grabbed the key from under the false rock, and ran toward the bathroom. Jack was eager to get…home.

As the twins entered the bathroom, their spirits plummeted. The mirror was gone, leaving the wall depressingly empty. They both drooped.

"What…what happened?" Jack asked.

"The Mirror Tappers have stolen the mirror. Quick, we need to search this house for any Mirror Tappers lurking around waiting for us," Daniel said with authority.

"Okay, let's split up!" Jack said.

"Good, that way they can't catch us both at once. But we'll be stronger together…"

"Let's go."

The boys left the bathroom and scoured the house. Jack went left to the kitchen and Daniel went right to their bedroom.

Daniel quickly strode into the room, after checking there were no skeletons waiting to close it in on him. He checked under the bed and behind the black-out curtains swiftly. He slowed down when he got to the closet. A year ago in this same spot he had been captured and imprisoned. Daniel saw a flashback of the door creaking open. Then he realized it

wasn't a hallucination. There was a pair of purple eyes peering out at him, and the door was starting to slide open.

Jack ran into the kitchen. There was already a Mirror Tapper in plain sight. It was a Vampire. It had a tall collar and a pale head with only a few hairs. His cloak almost reached the ground. It was holding the mirror. Jack leaped forward trying to touch the mirror. But the Vampire's arm shot out and knocked Jack off his balance. Jack groped forward with all the strength he had. He felt a bite in his arm, then something cold, and then…

Daniel's dad up on the second floor in his office heard a shatter from downstairs. He heard many footsteps. He immediately ran down the stairs and up into the hallway that led to the kitchen. What he saw was a mirror in millions of pieces all over the floor with Jack under them and a tall, pale faced fellow on top of everything. He didn't know who either of these people were. He just knew they were in his house, and at least one of them was getting hurt. Daniel's dad ran toward them.

Jack's dad up on the second floor in his office heard a shatter from downstairs. He left his desktop, flew down the steps, and went to the main hallway. What *he* saw was a shattered mirror all over the floor that was… moving. Yes, a few of the pieces were actually moving around. He didn't know how these pieces were slithering, nor did he realize his son was not currently in his universe. He just knew he had better stay back and maybe call the police. Jack's dad started to move back up the stairs.

Daniel jumped backwards. The door slid fully open and a Skeleton emerged. He positioned himself, then he sprung for the door. He reached it before Daniel and quickly shoved himself against it to block Daniel's escape—he couldn't lock it because of his uncoordinated, spiney hands. He reached forward and threw his silver sword at Daniel's foot. Daniel had just enough reaction time to pull his leg back. But it wasn't enough. The sword pierced the very end of his left sneaker. It didn't go into Daniel's foot, luckily, but he was thrown off his balance and fell backwards. The Skeleton pulled the sword out of Daniel's shoe and…

He stopped mid-thrust.

Jack needed to escape. The bat had bit him, leaving a lasting drowsiness that made it harder to move than normal. He had hit the mirror with his arm. He had not teleported. Later he figured that the Vampire had disabled the mirror with magic in order to carry it around and not be teleported out of the battle. Right before he had touched it, the Vampire had morphed into a bat and bit Jack's right arm. When Jack hit the glass, it fell to the ground and shattered like a fragile chandelier. Now Jack pressed his hand against the shards. Without proper formation they were dead—cold and lifeless. Jack spun away from the bat's—now Vampire again—grip. He bumped the kitchen table and scurried under it. It collapsed when the Vampire jabbed at him. Jack picked himself up and ran while the Vampire was getting up. He ran into his—Daniel's he realized later—dad. He zoomed out of the door. He ran and ran and ran until he was out of breath. And he didn't look back.

Daniel's dad raced forward toward the intruders. He pushed the child aside and ran at the witch-like creature. It looked much more evil than the little kid that was running away from his house. Nathan Charleson pushed the table down on top of the Vampire. However, before he realized it, he felt a sharp pain in his shoulder and he fell to the ground. A poof of smoke and a bat had zoomed out of the door and into the afternoon sky.

Jack's dad raced back up the stairs. The door swung open. He didn't know it, but he was in the first ever Mirror Collision, an event that randomly takes objects from one side of the mirror and makes them show up on the other and vice-versa. In the dark tower that was the Mirror Tappers' base—the one where Daniel had been captured—the evil ruler was conjuring up a malicious storm of chaos. She wanted the Jack Twins dead. And so she was extending all her energy into the pinnacle that sat upon the tower. Lightning streamed from it. The captives in the jail room quaked. Everything in the tower shook. Normally when something is changed on one side of the mirror and not on the other, only one side changes. Everything stays the same, that is, until a mirror dies. Then there is a short gap of time when it is possible that a Mirror Collision, or a Mirror *Storm*, can be created with enough energy. And that is what the dark ruler of the dark tower had been

waiting for. She wanted a Storm. And if she could collide everything, the Mirror Tappers would be alive again, and she would be ruler of all.

Daniel looked into the eyes of the Skeleton. He wasn't not striking out of pity. He was doing it out of obedience. The queen had said she wanted the twins alive before her, and then they would die. A hideous death. And so the Skeleton stopped, rushed forward, grabbed Daniel, and made for the closet. Daniel screamed. His head hurt. It was happening again. And he knew where he would be in less than fifteen seconds if he didn't do something…but there was nothing he could do. He had one weapon but he was saving it for the last hope. And he still had time.

Chapter 10

Before the Queen

Daniel was dragged into a large room. He was in shackles and chains, being pulled by two Skeletons. A large throne was set in the middle of the back of the room.

Slowly the throne began to float off the ground. Then it rose until it reached the top of the high ceiling and flew through a small gap. Then the throne descended until it was hovering just a couple feet above the ground. But on the way down there was a woman on it. The Queen was tall, pale skinned, and had midnight black hair. Her eyes had purple irises and she wore a long purple robe. In her hand she held a glowing purple orb. She turned to look at Daniel.

"*What* is this puny creature? Bring him closer so I may see…" the Evil Queen demanded.

The Skeletons pulled Daniel until he was five feet in front of the Queen's throne.

"He is the first Jack twin. But I need the other as well. I have an experiment planned," the Evil Queen cackled evilly. "Take him away to solitary confinement and feed him nothing but bread and water!"

The Skeletons laughed and started to drag him screaming toward the hallway. Was this the time to use his weapon? No. Something in his gut told him it was not that time. Yet.

Chapter 11

The House

Jack finally slowed his run to a trot. He was exhausted. And he felt terrible. He had left Daniel in the house where he was sure there would be more Mirror Tappers. But where was he now? He had run into the woods that was at the end of his neighborhood. The trees varied from saplings to huge, weathered oaks. Multicolored leaves carpeted the ground.

Jack looked around. He had never been this far into the forest. He didn't recognize any of the trees. He hoped no bears lived around his neighborhood. He kept walking in the direction he was headed. Soon he saw a puff of smoke in the distance. "*What is that?*" Jack thought. He ran toward it. Soon he stumbled upon a small cottage. Smoke streamed from the chimney, but Jack couldn't see any movement in the windows.

He cautiously approached. He rapped on the solid oak door but to no answer. He pushed the door slowly open. The room smelled strongly of smoke and fish. Jack stepped in more. He couldn't see anyone. "Hello?" Jack asked. No answer.

Jack walked up to the fireplace. Several dead fish were in the process of being cooked. A tight band wound around the spittle and another wheel and slowly made the fish turn. A heap of coal was next to the fireplace. In the corner of the house was a small white bed, and a dresser that Jack assumed clothes were in. A wooden box with a latch was on top of the dresser. A small, open door led to a small, dusty bathroom. A cane leaned against the wall. The only other furniture in the room was an oak desk with maps and other papers all over it.

Jack strolled over to the desk with his hands behind his back and looked at the papers. One in particular caught his eye. It was a blueprint for

a tower. There was a pinnacle on top. Inside the pinnacle, in a glass case, was an orb. Below the steeple, in a room, was a throne. An arrow that went up and down indicated that the throne could float between the top floor, and a chamber beneath the top floor. The chamber appeared to be a throne room of sorts. Jack didn't recognize any of this, of course, but his eyes wandered down where the tower got wider and there were many rooms. There he noticed a large cavern. It was filled with beds, desks, bins, bathrooms, and other household essentials. Then he noticed a chute with a door covering it that led up to a room above, and then into a hallway. Could this be…

A gruff voice interrupted Jack's thought. "What do you think you're doing in here?"

Chapter 12

The Old Man

Jack turned around, pale faced, to see an old man with a white beard watching him. Jack expected that he had been standing there for a while, just hadn't said anything.

"Oh, um…long story?" Jack stammered.

"Tell it." The man said, looking more kindly. He pulled a chair from a closet in the bathroom and set it before Jack. The man himself went over to the fireplace and pulled the fish off the spittle. He said, "Just a moment," and then he left for a minute and returned with a jug of the clearest water Jack had ever seen.

"So, again I ask you: who are you and why are you in my cabin?" the man asked, sitting down in the desk chair.

"Well, I can't really tell you unless…you tell me who *you* are," Jack said slowly.

The man handed Jack a fat slice of fish and a glass of the spring water.

“I was not born in this world,” the man started, “I grew up in a cloudy land far, far away. My father and mother were the king and queen of the country. Then one day my parents went on a trip. They wanted to see the world below. They returned with very interesting news of things called ‘cars’ that had wheels and moved all on their own, and other things called ‘Skyscrapers,’ which were just *really* tall towers made out of glass. It sounded so cool, that one day I decided to leave home and go there. But another important decision was being made.

“My parents ordered that no one was to leave the cloud land. It was ‘too dangerous’ to go and the Belowlanders would be upset to see all the strange people. But I was gone. When they found that I had left, they were shocked. However, my parents had made a rule and they were bound to keep it. I was locked out forever.

“Blinded by anger, sadness, and the feeling of being betrayed, I began to search for a relic. It was a silver necklace with a ruby shaped like a tiny dagger. But in order to get this necklace, I had to fight many perils and give up my conscience for three years. On my way to get it, I found some other special stuff like this magic key—”

The man paused to pull out a golden key. He tossed it to Jack. “It molds to whatever keyhole you put it in. I don’t need it anymore, so take care of it for me. Don’t do any mischief with it…”

He continued the story, “I locked myself in a cave during those three, long, slow cycles of the planet earth. But before the last year was up, the Rebels found me.

“The Rebels are a group of my kindred that rebelled against the royals. They abandoned the rules and left. They formed right after the new ‘Belowlander’ rule had been introduced. The Rebels were influential and strong, and so my mother knew she had to do something about it before she and my father were killed. And so she used her magical orb to curse the Rebels. They transformed into horrid, evil creatures in the form of Skeletons, Vampires, and strong warriors called Borgs. But worse than the transformation in looks, they were banned from seeing themselves in the mirror. It is a legend that my great-great-great-great-great-great grandfather

created the mirror. He had such a close connection with his creation that they say he could see anyone looking at themselves in the mirror.

"The Rebels now had the ability to teleport between dimensions. But this forced them to send some of their troops on the opposite side of the mirror in order to stay protected. They didn't like this. It made them weak, and they were now complete outcasts. But they had one hope to merge back to normal. And that was to collect forty-nine *whole* human souls and burn them all at once in the presence of the ruby necklace.

"And so that was why I wanted the ruby. I would return it to my mother where she could dispose of it and bring me back into the kingdom where I would live a normal life again. Alas, in the cave the Rebels stole my necklace and took it to the cloud land. They had collected four and a half human souls—obviously the half was just a person on one side of the mirror—but they had nowhere to keep them. In a burst of power, the Rebels stormed my mother's tower and took her captive. No one has seen her since. They killed my father—as I am told—and his body was seen in a cemetery. In the tower, drastic changes occurred. The Rebels set aside one room for the captives, and they set about stealing people in a strategic order, making sure they cast spells of 'forgetfulness' on the Belowlanders and take both halves of the soul.

"So that's pretty much the story. I know you probably don't believe any of it, and that's okay. I'm just a crazy old man to you, but let's hear your story," the man concluded and started to eat his fish.

"Well, okay, but can I ask you a question first?" Jack asked.

"Sure."

"Umm... I've just been in a fight with some Rebels and I'm sort of curious why it just *happened* to be the prince of Mirror Tapper land that lived in a cottage behind my house. Any confessions?" Jack asked inquisitively, ready to bolt.

"Oh! That," the man said, "I forgot that my house only appears to unbalanced subjects of the mirror spectrum. So you've really been in a fight with them? They're here? Tell me more."

Jack took a deep breath, then he started to talk.

Chapter 13

Prison

Daniel paced back and forth. His prison cell was dark and cold. The guards had left him several small pieces of maggot-infested bread, which, after days of only muddy water, he greedily gobbled up in less than a minute. Now he walked slowly about, for there was nowhere to sit, and thought of what to do.

"*I have to break free!*" one side of Daniel said.

"*No, we must still wait, the climax is yet to come…*" thought the other.

"*But I can't just sit around doing nothing!*"

"*Thinking is the best thing we can do.*"

Daniel hobbled over to the door again. There was no window in this jail cell, for it was solitary confinement, but there was a heavy stone door with three locks on it.

"*Just maybe we can break these locks…*" said side one of Daniel.

"*Yeah, you and what key? And even if you do, you'll never get past the 24/7 guards,*" scoffed side two of Daniel.

"*We can at least try!*" side one argued.

"*Fine.*"

Daniel got down on his hands and knees to look into the keyhole. It was *very* dark, and he couldn't see a thing. Wait, was that a glimmer of yellow? He reached his hand in and pulled out a piece of shiny gold. Daniel was hopeful. He looked in all the other keyholes, but he found nothing. Gold couldn't help him here. He put the gold in his pocket and wondered how gold got into a solitary confinement cell. Maybe a previous prisoner had been trying to pick the lock with his false tooth? He hoped not.

Finally, Daniel slumped down again the wall, defeated, and eventually went to sleep.

Chapter 14

Drowning

Jack and the old man, whose real name was actually Mr. Corinth, finally stumbled out of a long hallway and into an empty room with one door. They had just stepped into the cloud portal, which was actually just two mirrors facing each other. The mirrors appeared to make a passage that was infinitely long. But there was an end. Corinth had a closet in his mirrorless bathroom that held two blue-rimmed mirrors. He held them close and then both he and Jack stepped in between the gap. They then walked into the left mirror and kept walking. They went until they could see the room and the door. Then they ran until they were out of breath.

The portal passage started to shrink mirror by mirror until nothing was left. Jack ran to the door of the room and yanked it open. They were at the end of a hallway. At the other end was another intersecting hallway. Lined along the walls were weapons. But not to grab and use. They were weapons pointed at Jack and Corinth. An alarm in some hidden corner of the hallway started blaring and the spear-throwing arms turned to Corinth. He had tears in his eyes. He had feared to use the portal passage until now, when he knew the Rebels were on the brink of gaining their freedom back. He had not been in his old kingdom since he was a little boy, jumping down to the magic barrier to see the Belowland.

Jack grabbed Corinth and shoved him through the door. Muddy water started to fill the empty room. The door locked and sealed automatically. They could have escaped through the door, had it been breakable, but that was not all that happened. A stone block slid to block the sealed door. Jack rushed to the block and tried to push it back. He even banged on the door. But, alas, he was too weak and the stone barrier overpowered him, leaving him and the old man in an empty room. They were trapped!

Corinth regained his normal air, and he yelled to Jack to go to the water hole on his side and plug it up. Corinth waded to a small crack in the wall that was spewing water and bubbles. He stuck his finger in the hole, but it only served to slow the steady flow. He was starting to panic.

A drop of water fell and clogged Jack's vision. He looked up from where he was standing next to the old man, with his finger in the leak. The ceiling was abnormally high and had several cracks that dripped water. Had it been designed this way for a reason?

"Corinth," Jack ordered, "Pull out the map of the tower you got from your mother when you were little."

Corinth fumbled in his wet back pocket and pulled out a soggy, blue paper. He handed it to Jack. Jack searched for a second, then he placed his finger on a chamber marked "Portal Room." He looked around it. This room was an extension of the tower that led into a sewage area. That explained the filth in the water. He looked around more. Then he noticed that the ceiling was high for a reason. The roof was part of the floor of the sewage system. So in order to save materials, the construction workers had simply made the roof a little higher when they were drilling out the room, and it cost them less time and money. But this might have been the golden ticket to the duo's escape.

Jack showed Corinth the building flaw. Then he pointed to the cracks in the ceiling. The old man agreed that it might be their only hope of escape. They pulled out stones they had collected from around Corinth's cabin and started chucking them at the rusty ceiling.

At first, little happened (except for Jack getting hit in the face several times by a falling stone). But their rocks were leaving small dents in the surface of the roof. They aimed for the same spot and soon they started feeling more water droplets fall and seeing more cracks appear.

But to counter this new-found hope, the water level was rising very high. They could barely stand normally anymore. Jack was worried for Corinth. He was old and not as spry as he used to be. Could he tread water long enough to reach the roof?

Eventually their feet left the ground and they could only touch it by diving. Corinth sputtered, but, with some difficulty, treaded high enough above the water to breathe. Jack was thinking that the old man didn't know how to swim. But now Jack was very thankful for all those dumb "swim lessons" his mother made him do when he was little. Of course, he still

strongly disliked the annoying graduate girls who taught the classes, but he had a new appreciation for the art of swimming.

They continued to throw rocks at the ceiling. Soon Jack was pretty sure they were going to get out. Well, "*Maybe me, but what's going to happen to Corinth? Is he going to be able to make it?*" he thought. Jack now sort-of understood how the sewer system above was operating. There was a thin constant stream of running water going through the pipes, but every once in a while a wave of foul water would surge down through the sewer system, leaving Corinth and Jack soaked.

Finally they made it. Jack pulled himself, soaked, onto the dark, rusty sewer platform. The edge was about five feet thick, so it took a lot of arm muscle to drag himself up. Of course, Corinth was a different story. He was a miserable blob now. Jack figured he would have to wait for the water to be higher before Corinth would get out. Jack shouted words like "Hang in there," and "Just a little further now," to the struggling old man below.

And then they were together. Corinth was very tired. He asked Jack to let him rest for a little while. And then they set off together in the direction of the throne room.

Chapter 15

Escape

Daniel was awoken by a click and a snap. He had been having troubled dreams about blood and arrows and sharp things, but now all he could hear was…the door opening?

Daniel opened his eyes. His back was very stiff from napping against the wall. But what was this? The door was opening? Two of the three locks had already been undone and the third was sliding open. Here came the moment. His demise. He fingered a toothpick shaped object in his pocket, ready to pull it out.

The door creaked open. Daniel sucked in his breath. Jack walked in.

"Daniel?!" Jack said at the same time Daniel said, "Jack?!"

Daniel rushed to hug him. Was this his escape?

“Come on,” Jack said. “The sewers are right around the corner. We have to run before the guards get us!”

“Okay!” Daniel said, straightening his posture and starting to leap out of the doorway.

In the hallway, everything was a complete disaster. Blunt arrows were lying about on the ground and several cracked spears leaned against the wall precariously. Just as the hallway guarding the portal room had been lined with weapon throwers, so had solitary confinement room #1. Jack had had to disable all the machines as well as avoid their deliberate attacks on him. The Queen was venting half of her force on protecting Daniel. The other half was on the Storm, growing and causing more things to merge.

As the two boys ran down the hallway, Daniel noticed a small arrow sticking into Jack’s foot. Blood muddied his shoe. Jack had been *injured* trying to free him. Maybe he would get infected. He wouldn’t be able to walk for much longer…

Jack turned the corner, suddenly ducking. An arrow whizzed over his head a moment later. Daniel ducked down as Jack bolted forward toward the assailer. He hit his stomach full force and knocked him off balance. Jack grabbed the crossbow and shoved it into the second guy’s throat. He toppled over Guard #2 and grabbed his club. Daniel realized the danger and ran to help Jack. Guard #1 kicked Jack and started to get up. But as he rolled off, a reddish-brown circle was revealed. The manhole cover shot off and a hand dragged Jack’s foot toward the darkness. Jack complied and Daniel figured it was all part of the plan. So he dashed for the hole and jumped in before the two guards could pick themselves up.

“OWWW!!” a man screamed as soon as Daniel landed. “Careful where you jump, sonny!” It was Corinth.

Jack dragged the manhole cover down as quickly as he could. Guard #1 had just sprung and Jack got his finger trapped between the cover and the floor. The pain was so intense that Jack lost consciousness, if only for a second. He recoiled his finger and fell onto the floor. Corinth examined him. “We can’t get help right now, but we have to move. The guards are

gonna open that cover somehow, and we don't want to be there when it happens."

All three of them fled down the hallway, with Jack moaning in pain. After turning several corners, they sat down to rest.

Corinth and Jack had emerged from the portal room safely. They had rested and then marched onward towards the throne room. But when they had gotten under a manhole cover, and the floor was above them, they overheard two guards having a conversation:

Guard #1: "Are you sure we can just leave?"
Guard #2: "Yes, pea-brain. We go to the guard room, tell Risky and Andrew that it's their shift, and then we're off."
Guard #1: "Okay, but I'm telling you, the Queen is strict. She doesn't want anyone leaving the *special* prisoner unguarded."
Guard #2: "Let's go."

Naturally, they wanted to check out who this prisoner was. Corinth was too weak to climb out of the cover, but Jack wanted to investigate. He disabled the machines by getting them to throw their weapon, and then right before they could pick it up again, he raced out from behind the corner and grabbed it. Finally he got to Daniel's prison cell, used Corinth's special magic key he had found on his journey to find the ruby to unlock the door. The rest has already been explained.

All this Jack and Corinth told Daniel while they rested. Suddenly they heard a *Clank!* Daniel jumped up. "The guards are here," he whispered. They heard footsteps. More than two.

"They brought other guards," hissed Jack. "Let's get out of here!"

Chapter 16

Between a Rock and an Evil Queen

Following the blueprint map, Jack, Corinth, and Daniel moved as quickly as they could toward the throne room. Jack had to limp. They turned a couple of corners. The luminance of the tunnel behind them grew. Finally they reached the spot where the sewer system was right under a hallway that led directly to the throne room. Everyone had severe jitters.

They looked up. Daniel's hopes plummeted. The manhole cover above them had been sealed. The Queen must have been notified and had sealed every possible manhole. This was going to be *really* hard.

Jack turned. The light behind them was growing and he could hear footsteps. How had they known they were here?

"We have to go, now!" Jack whispered.

All three of them started to move. Jack suddenly fell. He bit his lip to prevent a scream of pain, but Corinth and David could tell he was in intense anguish. Daniel thought for a moment, then he said, "There's only one thing to do. We'll have to carry you, Jack."

Corinth nodded and both of them put their arms under Jack and started to carry him. They were slow but got faster as time progressed. But the men were faster still. Daniel and Jack were lost themselves. They had turned so many corners that they weren't sure how the guards were still following them. Then Daniel noticed something on the arm he was holding.

Jack's arm was smarting. There was a small bite-shaped mark that glowed red. "What's that?" Daniel asked.

Jack said nothing. But Corinth stared for a second, then he said, "It's where the vampire bit him. Of course! That explains a lot. The vampire left a tracking device. That way they could find him and bring him to the Queen."

"I'll bet she's enraged that I escaped," Daniel said.

"No," Corinth politely disagreed, "I think she has you caught," —except it wasn't Corinth who said it. It was a much deeper voice.

Suddenly a band of guards came up in front of them. They turned to go the other way but there were more. Trapped. Again.

Chapter 17

The Experiment

The Queen stared cruelly at the three intruders. She grinned. But there was something about the old one, "*Corinth,*" the Queen thought, "*that's what they call him.*" She recognized something in his face. Had she see him before? She decided to ignore her curiosity and get on with her plan.

"It's so good to see all of you!" The Queen gave them a flashy smile.

Corinth grunted and Daniel scowled. Jack just stood there all sad looking. His wound had been given a quick treatment, but it was far from healed. The arrow had been pulled and a potion had been poured over it. Jack had done his best to rub the bite on his arm with? his foot while the potion was still wet. He hoped maybe it would cure the bite a little. But there were no visible results.

"Aww. You're not glad to see me? Well, that doesn't matter. Because I have a little… *experiment* planned." The Evil Queen's throne started to hover.

"You won't get away with this!" Daniel yelled.

"Oh! But you haven't even heard what I'm going to do!" the Queen said maliciously.

Corinth looked at her. Something about her face seemed familiar to him too. But he couldn't quite put his finger on it.

The Queen's throne rose higher. She raised her hand up toward the ceiling, and then slowly, a purple orb floated down into her extended hand. "Do you see this?" she said, "it is the Orb of Kelton, my five greats grandfather's prized possession! He owes the creation of the mirror to it. Allow me to tell you a little story."

It was obvious neither of the twins wanted to hear the story. They wanted to tell her: "No!" but Corinth was obviously hooked. This lady was part of his six greats grandfather's family line! It could have been his mother's cousin, or even sister! So they listened.

“Neil Kelton was a powerful engineer. Not a *mechanical* engineer, obviously, but a *magical* engineer. One day he wanted something to let his wife see how beautiful she was. He came out with a sheet of polished metal. She could only see a skewed image of herself, and she wanted more. Neil worked day and night to create the perfect viewing device. But he couldn’t figure it out. Until one day an old hag knocked on his door. It was snowing outside, so he allowed the lady to come in. She repaid his hospitality with a gift—a magical orb. He looked into it and saw himself. But there was something so real about it. Like there really *was* another him looking through the orb.

“He was overtaken by greed. He kept the mirror to himself and never let another soul see it. But he used the orb to create a cheap imitation. The mirror was shiny and clean. His wife loved it. But she never knew he had something better…” The Queen stopped.

“Why are you telling us this!” Daniel asked.

“One day, Neil fell into a trance while looking into the orb. Eventually, he found he was no longer in the real world. He was trapped in the mirror. He is still wandering around, never resting. He has shown up to people numerous times by looking through mirrors. But he is unhappy.”

“That still doesn’t answer my question!” Daniel yelled. “Why did you tell us this?”

With an evil smile, she spoke to the orb, “Oh Neil! Why don’t you come out and say hello to our guests?”

At first nothing happened. The Queen scowled. Then slowly, the Orb of Kelton rippled like the surface of a pond and then a man’s face came into focus.

The face was old. Like, older than anything Jack or Daniel or even Corinth had ever seen. It held similarities to the Queen’s face and Corinth’s. But it was different from both. Plus, his eyes looked entranced and unearthly.

“What have you brought me here for, Girda?” Neil asked slowly without much emotion.

“Don’t use my real name!” the Queen said angrily.

“Fine, answer my question.”

“Remember our little deal?”

Suddenly Neil’s eyes darkened. “No…” he said, terrified.

“Yes!” the Evil Queen said triumphantly, “Guards! Come and bind these young men together. But shoot the old one with your bow—outside.” She turned to the Orb of Kelton, “As for you... perform the spell!”

The guards seized Daniel and Jack—not without a fight, of course. But when they grabbed Corinth, he just stood there, dazed. Jack looked at him. Mr Corinth was staring at the Queen, wide-eyed. He was breathing short, raspy breaths. “No…” he said under his breath, “It can’t be…”

The Queen paid no mind. “Neil,” she said sweetly, “Please tell the twins what you are about to do to them.”

This was a moment neither boys would ever forget. Neil shakily started to gasp out a few words, “Merge… I will merge you two… into one.”

That was enough for both boys to stop breathing and turn as still as stone.

But Corinth was already a marble statue. He looked like he had just seen a ghost.

The Queen turned to him. “What is wrong with the old fool?!” she said to the guards and Corinth at the same time.

They shrugged. “Would you still like us to kill him?” the leader Skeleton asked.

“No,” the Queen said hesitantly, “I…” she trailed off. The face seemed so familiar… like a face from a dream. She knew she couldn’t be weak, she had to follow through. But still…

Corinth leaned forward, and he finally mumbled one word:

“Mom?”

Chapter 18

Family

The Queen's face lit up in recognition for a second and then she clenched her fists and scowled. "Take him away and have him shot. Right now."

"But… mom! Why would you do this? I'm your son—you're my mother."

"I *was* your mother," she said, trying to look emotionless. But she obviously was having trouble. A little mist cleared from her eyes. The guards stopped dragging Corinth away and let the conversation play out.

"Why would you leave me? I was just… *curious*." Corinth started to get angry, "Do you not know what you did to me? You ruined my *life*! I thought we were *family*! But maybe you didn't think that. And why… why did you join *them*? How could you!? Your loyalty was to the kingdom! Not to the...the…*Rebels*!" Corinth was seething. Jack started to get more alert. He knew about Corinth's childhood, but Daniel did not. Speaking of Daniel, he was very confused. He had no clue how this evil woman was this nice man's mother. It was all so odd...

"Silence!" the Queen yelled, "I know none of it made sense to you at the time, and I know it's all really confusing. But I was protecting the kingdom. And I was protecting you."

"How?!" Corinth was in tears. "How did leaving me in a strange world as a toddler *protect* me? I see now that the threads of madness were already working their way around you! And now you're going to destroy more innocent children's lives. And two in one hit!"

The mist in the Queen's eyes cleared for a moment, revealing two beautiful, pearly eyes. "You're *right*…" she paused, and then the darkness flooded back in. "You're right that I'm going to destroy these children's *life*!" She let out an evil cackle. But something like guilt hung in her throat. She wouldn't let anyone know, but it was there.

"Commence the operation!"

Chapter 19

Fire

The guards laughed and dragged Corinth away. Neil gulped and started to mumble words. The Queen slumped in her chair and bittersweetly watched her foul plan be carried out.

But Daniel had not been watching this scene passively. All the while he had been loosening the bonds of his wrists and working his way toward his back pocket. Finally he got a grip on the toothpick shaped object and drew it out of his pocket. His hands were behind his back, so all spectators were unaware of his oncoming action.

He rubbed the stick against his pants over and over again. When he felt a little heat, he pressed the stick against the rope. The area began to singe as Neil slowly said a couple more words. He strangely seemed aware of Daniel's move.

"Come now, Neil." The Queen said, "let's get this over quickly."

Neil stayed focused and kept his slow and steady pace.

Daniel tugged on the rope which he could feel was almost ready to snap. The tension in the air grew. At first both of them figured they were imagining it. But then they realized they weren't. The spell was starting to pull them together. Daniel had to act fast.

Neil started to utter the second to last line. Daniel strained against the rope and…it snapped. He jumped up and ran away from Jack. The force was growing, but the distance he put between them was enough to stall the collapse.

"What sorcery is this?!" The Queen yelled after a stunned second. "Guards!"

Three guards rushed in from the hallway. They lunged at Daniel, trying to pull him into their control. Daniel dodged left, then right. He narrowly ducked under a reaching hand to run right into another one. This one trapped him. He was in trouble. He spun and rolled off the bony arm. Now all the Skeletons were behind him. He sprinted for the exit. Then he felt a sharp pain in his back. The only thing keeping him from fainting now was

adrenaline. And right before he reached the exit, he jumped and tapped the small circular mirror above the doorway. He vanished.

Chapter 20

Orb

Jack was watching. Daniel had been hit in the back by a Skeleton's sword and had nearly tripped. But he kept going until he reached the mirror where he had gone to the other side. Doubtless, Jack assumed, there would be more Skeletons on the other side and it was just a matter of time before they captured Daniel.

Daniel's foot suddenly appeared in the air. "*What?!*" Jack thought. What was happening? But The Queen knew. It was the Storm. She had been planning this for a long time. It was the destruction of the mirror. It was the merging of everything. And who was going to go first? Jack Daniel Charleson.

Daniel's whole body appeared for a second. Then he disappeared again. Several Skeletons appeared and disappeared as well. The Queen's victory was in sight. Daniel flickered. He was headed for Jack. Jack wanted to yell something like, "Stay away, we're going to merge!" or, "Daniel, attack The Queen!" but he was paralyzed.

Daniel's hand touched Jack. It flickered out of existence and then it was gone. Wait, had Daniel just did what Jack thought he did? Yes, he had snapped Jack's cords with the Skeleton's sword. Jack was free!

Now was the time to move. The world was going to end—or at least the world as he knew it—and it seemed like there was nothing he could do. Jack looked at Neil through the orb. He looked as powerless as Jack felt. Neil's eyes connected with his. Neil was blinking slowly. Wait…was this Morse Code?

Jack and Daniel had always loved Morse Code. They had convinced Chad to learn it, too, and they used it as a secret language. But was Neil trying to tell him something?

Daniel glitched fully into view and he was attacking The Queen. Jack saw the sharp fingertip too late to warn Daniel, and The Queen's poisoned nail sunk into Daniel's flesh. Daniel collapsed at The Evil Queen's feet. It was all up to Jack now.

Bliiink. *Bliiink*. *Bliiink*.

That was Neil's message. An unnaturally long pause followed as Neil muttered some incandations in the binding curse. Jack's eyes seemed forced to wander to Daniel, but with all his will, Jack kept staring at the Orb of Kelton. Neil made another letter.

Blink. *Bliiink*. *Blink*.

This one was an "R" whereas the other was an "O." The Queen smiled as Jack started to slide toward Daniel. Daniel's arms flew out toward Jack. The next letter was very slow in coming.

Bliiink. [Pause] *Blink*. [Deep breath] *Blink*. *Blink*. [Sigh]

Jack had it. And it only took a second for him to figure out *exactly* what he was going to do in the next few moments. But it took all his strength and courage to make himself do it.

Daniel and Jack collided into each other. Jack's finger started to melt into Daniel's palm. He pulled himself back. He had to do it now or never. He dragged himself out of Daniel and lunged at the Orb of Kelton. It rolled off of the arm of The Queen's chair. She screamed and stuck her hand out at Jack. But he was ready for her. He barely evaded her poisonous finger and threw his arms around the orb. Daniel started to literally fly toward Jack. Neil was almost at the end of his spell with just two more words.

And then Jack did it.

You know how in movies everything goes really slow when someone punches somebody or says something really sad or something important like that? Well it's definitely real. Jack held the Orb of Kelton high in the air for a fraction of a second, and then he hurled it down. Onto the hard, stone floor.

And it shattered.

Because the last letter of the message was "B," and the message was "ORB."

Chapter 21

Power Outage

The Queen let out a blood curdling scream. All the lights went dark. Daniel's lifeless arms dropped from Jack and the tension between them snapped, sending each other skidding in opposite directions. The Queen threw herself off the throne and lunged at Jack. If she was going out, she was going to take him too.

Jack was in a daze. Had he really just done that? But he didn't have time to ponder his newfound courage, because in a couple seconds his back was pressed against the shards of the Orb of Kelton, and The Queen was strangling him. Her nails pressed into his neck and he started to feel woozy. The last thing he heard before he dropped off was Corinth yelling, "I'm coming for you, Jack!" Everything went black.

Chapter 22

Dream?

Jack woke up. He wondered to himself, "*Am I dead? Is this the afterlife?*" Then he remembered that all the book characters say that as soon as they wake up after the climax, so he figured not.

"Jack? Are you awake?" It was Corinth speaking.

Jack sat up. He was in a gorgeous, sun-filled room on a white, clean bed. Corinth sat on a chair beside him.

"Wh-Where am I?" Jack asked.

"You're in my mother's tower," Corinth said, smiling.

"But...But… I thought she was evil." Jack was confused.

"She was. But she was being held under the power of the orb. Now that you destroyed it, she's back to normal and trying to right all her wrongs."

Jack pondered this for a while. He had a million questions. He opened his mouth to ask one, but Corinth cut him off, “Not now. You must rest. But this afternoon there will be a big feast and then you can ask all the questions you like.”

This seemed good to Jack, so he laid back and went to sleep again.

Chapter 23

Answers

Jack and Daniel sat at a huge table piled three feet high with all sorts of food. They were in a grand hall with golden chandeliers and great glass windows and patterned floors. All around them were men and women who belonged to Corinth’s and The Queen’s kingdom, including the royals themselves. As it turned out, Corinth’s name was actually not Corinth. He was “Jay Herald” and The Queen was “Girda Herald.”

Before the feast started, one of the knights praised Jack, Daniel, and Mr. Herald. Then they dug into the delicious food. After a while, both boys were stuffed. After everyone else was done eating, Mr. Herald, Queen Girda, and the twins walked out to a porch. The sun was headed toward the west but had not yet sunk. The air was cool and easy to breathe.

All four of them took a seat. Mr. Herald started the discussion.

“Now that we have all eaten well, let us discuss what has happened. I know you two probably have lots of questions, so let’s start. Daniel, you first.”

“Well, can you start by explaining how your majesty Queen Girda and you, Mr. Co—Herald—my bad—are related?” Daniel asked, trying to look polite.

And so Mr. Herald and Queen Girda explained the story that Mr. Herald had told Jack way back in his little house. Queen Girda interrupted several times to say how sorry she was for her behavior. When they were finished recounting the tale, Daniel asked Queen Girda a question.

“So, how come—in the throne room—when I went to the other side of the mirror—was Jack there? Or at least he was teleporting back and forth between both sides. And also, why were you trying to merge us?”

“Ah. That was the Mirror Storm. I created it as soon as the Witch in your house broke your mirror—we’ll have to get that fixed. Basically, it’s a force that tries to merge both sides of the mirror. And I was trying to merge you because…well…I thought maybe the—and I hate to say it—forty-nine souls spell would need it. Of course, I hated you more than any of the other people I had collected because you had escaped, so I tried it on you first. It was an experiment, like I said.”

Jack jumped into the conversation. “That brings up a good question. What happened to the rest of the convicts of your jail?”

“They’re still here. We can’t let them go until we erase their memories—and that *includes* yours. Belowlanders cannot be indulged with the knowledge of Upperland.”

“But—”

“Actually,” Corinth said, “it doesn’t matter—begging your pardon, your majesty. But now with the mirror destroyed, there is no way to get to Upperland. Because for the portal to be created you need two mirrors. And there’s not even one mirror—well, except for the few shards of the…yeah, the ‘o-r-b’.”

“Wait,” Daniel asked, “there’s no more mirrors?”

“Fortunately,” said The Queen, “when you broke the *thing* it undid all its work after forty-eight minutes.”

“Forty-eight?” Jack asked, “Why forty-eight?”

“Because that’s how many souls The Rebels collected. We had forty-eight, except for you. You were the last piece. But luckily you broke the puzzle.”

Jack blushed. He felt important. So did Daniel; he was grinning ear to ear.

“So…are you still wiping our memories?” Daniel asked.

“No point,” Queen Girda said reluctantly. “There’s no way we can reset the balance of the mirror. It was enough to take a couple people and have

one of them be gone a couple hours longer than the other, but now one side of the mirror has a dad in the hospital, and the other has an article being published about 'Spooky Action at a Distance.' The worlds will just have to separate and become entirely different. But there's nothing wrong with that now that The Rebels have been cured…"

When The Queen saw the twins' blank stares, she sighed and got up. She motioned for them to follow her down a hallway and into a room. In the room was a mirror. At first Jack was about to say, "There *is* another mirror!" but then he realized it wasn't a *mirror*, it was a *window*. She spoke to the mirror: "Show me Dipe's Nathan Charleson, please." The mirror rippled just like The Orb of Kelton had, and then it displayed a man in a white bed. It took Jack and Daniel just a moment before they realized who it was.

"Dad?!" they both said at once.

"No," Queen Girda said sadly, "Only Daniel's. He was the one bit by the vampire."

"But," Jack said, "I got bit by a vampire and I'm not in a serious condition."

"But that was a different sort of bite." Queen Girda informed him. "That was a tracking bite, and you paid dearly for it, if I do say so myself. The bite the vampire gave your twin's dad was a fatal one. But doctors in your Belowland are smart, and they have good poison control, even if they don't know much magic." She gave him a smile.

Daniel was sad. "When can I go back?"

"I don't know. And…well, your situation is complicated," The Queen said, embarrassed. "your parents don't actually remember who you are…or anyone else for that matter. It will take a long time before I collect enough pixie-dust to perform old-fashioned magic—that is, by hand. The stuff you saw me do before was all from relics like the o-r-b."

Daniel looked like he might cry. His dad was sick and he couldn't go and comfort him.

Mr. Herald put his arm on Daniel's shoulder. "I know it's hard to take in all at one time like this. But you have to be strong. Life will never be the

same. For any of us. Because every time you look in the mirror, you won't see your reflection. You'll only see a wall."

"Um…" Jack said, "I know this is a weird question, but what in the world is 'Urpa'? Queen Girda said '*Urpa's'* Nathan Charleson.'"

"Good question." Mr. Herald replied, "The two worlds are "Urpa" and "Dipe". Daniel's world is Dipe and yours is Urpa. When an Uplander falls through the barrier at the bottom of Upland, they go to whatever side they're already on. So, no crossing to another side."

Jack understood this. But then a realization creeped onto him. As Daniel changed the subject and asked a question about Rebels, time slowed to a blur for Jack. The words *no crossing to the other side* echoed in his mind. But that wouldn't be a problem except…

He was on Daniel's side.

Chapter 24

Goodbye

Jack sat on his bed in his room. He was crying quietly. Mr. Herald had told him that he was stuck. And he was sure he was. There was absolutely no way to get back to his own family.

Daniel, on the other hand, was being very optimistic. He was excited to get home soon and see his parents. His dad had recovered from the poison—he learned that from the magic window. Queen Girda had also told him that the mirror was partially made out of some of the shards of the orb. She said that as a warning not to stay around it too much, or he would become evil.

Soon winter came on. Jack and Daniel had lived in Upperland for several months. Sometimes Jack would go to the magic mirror and look at his parents. Some nights they would cry themselves to sleep. Jack did that often, too. But they didn't know he was still alive, and he knew *they* were. But, just like having a locked photo album, having the pictures and not being able to see them doesn't help anything. And so Jack was sad. And

his parents were sadder that their only son was gone. But both parties would have to cope, because nothing could be done about it.

Then one day a messenger came to the castle tower. He told Queen Girda that a powerful enchantress had been found. A week later, the queen's guards brought in the woman. After a little bit of bribing, she performed a spell on Daniel that would revive the memory of him in Underland. After the spell was complete, Daniel raced to the magic window to look at his parents. They were looking half-stunned.

"How could we have forgotten…that we had a son?" his dad was saying.

And so that is why Jack, Daniel, Mr. Herald, Queen Girda, and the enchantress were gathered around the large oak table for one last time before they would leave each other forever.

"Thank you so much for everything you've done for us," Daniel told Queen Girda.

"It's my pleasure to house such heroes as you and your twin," she said smiling.

"Wait, so we're like…heroes?!" Daniel exclaimed.

"Of course! And my son, here, as well," she said. Queen Girda and Mr. Herald had become good friends after The Orb of Kelton had been dispersed. They talked with each other all the time.

Jack sighed. He was going to live with Daniel. It would be weird having a brother who walked and talked almost exactly like him—although of course Daniel's mind was a year older. It would also be weird having a sibling, which he knew wasn't really special, but it was new for him. But it wouldn't be *his* parents. And that was what bugged him. Sure, they were basically the same people. But hanging around with Daniel had taught him that even though people can be exactly the same, they're still different... people. It was strange, but that's the way it felt to Jack.

"Are you okay, Jack?" Mr. Herald asked.

"No, but I'm ready."

"Don't forget you can still communicate with us once a day through the empty compact."

Jack knew what he was talking about. Earlier that morning Queen Girda had given them a tiny compact that didn't have any cosmetics in it, just a mirror—though it was really a window into Upperland. It could hang by a chain for easy transportation. It had a tiny sliver of the orb in it, and was connected to the large mirror in the tower. So they had set up a signal that at 8:30 pm they would talk for about five minutes, longer if needed, in order to stay in touch. It would be the only thing in Belowland that could communicate with Upperland.

And then they grabbed their things and went out the door. The party walked half a mile away from the tower until the ground began to get softer and they approached a fence. Beyond the fence was a hole that went down into nothingness.

"There's the sinkhole," Queen Girda remarked.

"When you two fall through it you will teleport back to Underland and you will never come back."

"You won't forget us, will you?" Jack asked.

"No, never. And I hope you won't forget *us* either. But we can still talk, so we won't be totally stranded from each other."

Then in one, long, heartfelt moment, Mr. Herald hugged Jack. Then he did the same for Daniel. Then they embraced Queen Girda, and finally they walked to the gate of the fence. Everyone had tears in their eyes. The gate swung open. Daniel looked back. Then he jumped forward. Jack gazed at his two friends. He had come so far from an ordinary kid. But it wasn't really any of his doing. He had done his best at the right moments and everything turned out fine. But now he had to say goodbye to all of it. And so he did.

And as Jack's feet left the ground and he plunged after Daniel, he yelled back to Queen Girda and Mr. Herald, "Goodbye!"

Epilogue

Jack licked the last of the ice cream and then popped the end of the sugar cone into his mouth. Daniel did the exact same thing at the exact same time. Sometimes it was fun to have a twin brother. They had worked out a signal to do the same thing at the same time. It was a blink of the left eye, and then two blinks of the right eye. It was fun to make people think they were seeing double.

The world was just recovering from what some physicists called a "Light Shock." Of course, they never really *told* anyone how it worked, and that was because they didn't actually know. Everyone panicked when their mirrors didn't work. But by now people had gotten used to using phone screens as mirrors, and they tried not to think about it too much.

And that was because thinking about it caused one's head to hurt. Very badly. Because nobody—I repeat, *nobody*—knew how it worked. Well, that's not quite true, because two young children named Jack and Daniel knew, and their parents as well. And so one year after the initial shock, everything was getting back to normal... *without* mirrors.

Jack got up off the park bench. His mom was still finishing her moose tracks ice cream. Of course, his parents knew who he actually was. It would be impossible to keep a secret from his twin's mother and father. And why should he want to? The whole world could know it if they wanted to. But of course, they didn't, and that was because it was much too confusing and unbelievable to explain.

His mom smiled at him. "Hey, Jackie! Isn't this ice cream great?"

"Yeah!" Jack said. It had taken both of them a while to start to get used to each other and be able to talk freely, but Amelia Charleson knew that it was an honor to parent a child from the other side of the mirror, and she and her husband did their best. Jack finished his remark with, "Lenad's Ice Cream is the best!"

"Why don't you go play with the other kids on the swing set? You too, Daniel." She motioned to him.

"We're not toddlers, mom."

“Well, neither are they.” She pointed to a group of three kids who were about Daniel and Jack’s age. There were two girls and one boy.

“Fine,” Jack and Daniel said simultaneously. “We’ll do it.”

Then they giggled. Not a girlish sort of giggle, but a mischievous giggle. And *then* Jack and Daniel hopped off the bench and ran to the playground.

It was a beautiful day.

Thank you for reading.
I hope you enjoyed this unabridged production of…
The Other Side of The Mirror!

Be on the lookout for the next book…
But I don’t know what it’s called yet.

Also be on the lookout for a *video*
about this. (It’s Lego)